3.1 Battles of Vicksburg and Gettysburg

Sometimes you can recall the exact moment when things suddenly change and get either much better or much worse. For Civil War generals, two battles in particular dramatically shifted the war's direction.

MAIN IDEA The battles of Vicksburg and Gettysburg were the key turning points in the Union's eventual victory in the Civil War.

SPLITTING THE CONFEDERACY

In the first months of 1863, the war was not going well for Union generals. In January, after a disastrous defeat at Fredericksburg, Lincoln replaced General **Ambrose Burnside** with General **Joseph Hooker** as commander of the Army of the Potomac. Then in May, Lee's army defeated Hooker's forces near **Chancellorsville**, Virginia. Hooker resigned after the loss and was replaced by General **George Meade**. Lee lost his own most capable commander when Stonewall Jackson was accidentally shot by one of his own soldiers. However, Lee's victory at Chancellorsville is widely considered his greatest of the entire war.

The battle that ensued further south, in Vicksburg, Mississippi, began to change the course of the war for the Union. By 1863, Vicksburg had been a Confederate stronghold for more than a year. Its position allowed the Confederacy to control a wide part of the region from **bluffs**, or cliffs, 200 feet above the Mississippi River. Capturing the city and silencing Confederate guns became a strategic necessity for the Union.

During the early spring of 1863, Union forces commanded by General Grant tried to find a way to take the city from their vantage point on the western bank of the river. But Confederate troops commanded by General **John C. Pemberton** turned them back. Then in early May, Admiral **David Porter,** under Grant's orders, ran a **flotilla**, or small fleet, of gunboats and barges past Confederate forces at Vicksburg under cover of night. Porter used these vessels to ferry Grant's troops across the river south of the city.

From there, Grant's troops marched northeastward before doubling back toward Vicksburg and cutting the city off from the east. In only three weeks, Grant's men marched 180 miles, won 5 battles, and captured 6,000 prisoners. Vicksburg was now surrounded and under siege. Food ran out and the residents began to starve. Pemberton surrendered on July 4, 1863. The Union victory at the **Battle of Vicksburg** gave the Union control of the Mississippi Valley and split the Confederacy in half. It also convinced President Lincoln of Grant's outstanding military ability.

THE TIDE TURNS AT GETTYSBURG

Despite his victory at Chancellorsville, Lee realized that the North's manpower advantage might be wearing down Confederate troops and that a victory on the attack would boost Confederate morale. He decided that his most effective move was to invade the North again. In late June 1863, Lee's troops advanced into Pennsylvania, where they met Meade's troops at the **Battle of Gettysburg**. At first, Lee succeeded in sending the Union troops into retreat. Then, on July 1, reinforcements arrived for both sides, bringing troop numbers to approximately 90,000 for the Union and about 75,000 for the Confederates. Union forces stopped retreating and stationed themselves on **Cemetery Hill**, where the high vantage point gave them a defensive edge.

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CRITICAL VIEWING Photography played a new and important role in the Civil War. This iconic photo, captured by Timothy O'Sullivan in July 1863, shows about 20 of the more than 3,100 fallen Union soldiers after the Battle of Gettysburg. What effect do you think this photo might have had on Americans who saw it in 1863?

On Friday, July 3, hoping to outflank Union forces on Cemetery Hill, Lee ordered Major General **George Pickett** and about 15,000 of his men to attack the Union troops on a plain just below the hill. Lee's strategy proved disastrous. The Union repelled Pickett's charge, killing or wounding more than half of Pickett's troops. The next day, Lee retreated, eventually crossing the Potomac River to Virginia. This retreat marked a turning point in the war. It put the Confederacy on the defensive and the Union in a favorable position for victory.

On November 19, 1863, President Lincoln delivered the **Gettysburg Address** at the battle site to commemorate the loss of so many men and to dedicate a military cemetery there. Throughout his speech, Lincoln referred to the Declaration of Independence directly and to its ideas. His address reinforced the Declaration's principles of equality and freedom for which the war was fought and for which so many died, and were still dying.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the battles of Vicksburg and Gettysburg affect the Civil War?
2. **IDENTIFY PROBLEMS AND SOLUTIONS** What challenges did Grant and his troops face, and how were they eventually able to capture the city of Vicksburg?
3. **EVALUATE** How did the Union's position on Cemetery Hill contribute to its victory at Gettysburg?

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